

Elicita Quick Start

Your first hour with Elicita, in the order you will meet it.

Elicita helps you ask the question you would otherwise have missed — while the client is still in the room — and then writes up what was agreed, quoting the words that were actually said.

The one thing to understand before you start: **almost everything that makes Elicita useful happens before anyone sits down.** The thinking is done days in advance so that during the meeting it only has to pick the right question from work already finished. If you do nothing else from this guide, do steps 2 to 5.

Read this in one sitting; the whole first pass takes about an hour, most of which is waiting for the question bank to draft.

The rest of this book walks the same path slowly, one screen at a time. This chapter is the short way through it.

Before you begin

You need one thing that somebody has to give you: **a credential for an AI provider.** Elicita uses outside services for two jobs — turning speech into text, and doing the writing-up — and the question drafting is the one you will hit in your first hour.

Two things you do *not* need:

- **A database.** Everything an engagement remembers is written to a single file on your machine as you work. Nothing to install.
 - **A Microsoft 365 registration** — unless you want to attach documents by SharePoint or OneDrive *link*. Dropping the files in needs nothing set up at all, and is the way in that always works.
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Step 1 — Point Elicita at the services it uses

Settings. Once, per machine. Five minutes.

On first run the Settings screen says plainly that nothing is configured, rather than looking ready and failing later. Each part carries its own verdict, so what is left to do can be read at a glance.

Settings

These settings are held in memory and will be lost when the service restarts.

Claude Needs a credential

Drafts the question bank before the meeting and writes the debrief after it. Nothing during the meeting waits on it.

Route Claude calls through

Calls api.anthropic.com with the credential below.

Anthropic

Authenticate with

Whichever your organisation issues. Only the one selected here is sent, and only its field is shown.

API key OAuth token

Anthropic API key

A key issued from the Anthropic console (starts sk-ant-).

Not configured Test

No key is stored yet.

Model

Used for the context compiler and the debrief pipeline.

claude-opus-5

Where the data is kept On this machine

Engagements, their meetings, the documents you attach and the words you add. A single file on this machine unless you point it somewhere else.

In use now

Read from the service, with any password removed.

sqlite:///home/you/elicta/state.db

Save

Where a linked SharePoint, OneDrive or Teams document is read...

Before anything is configured

The screen is a stack of parts. Most are an outside service, and that service's credential sits inside its own part under the name of the company that issued it — there is no list of keys to work out which goes where. The rest are choices about your own installation, and you can leave those as they are for now.

Fill in the **AI provider** part. You can point Elicita at the company that makes the service directly, at Amazon's, Google's or Microsoft's hosted versions, or at your organisation's own gateway. Choose Amazon or Google and no key is asked for at all — Elicita uses the permissions your cloud account already grants it, and the credential fields do not appear rather than sitting there greyed out.

Settings

Claude Ready

Drafts the question bank before the meeting and writes the debrief after it. Nothing during the meeting waits on it.

Route Claude calls through

Calls api.anthropic.com with the credential below.

Anthropic

Authenticate with

Whichever your organisation issues. Only the one selected here is sent, and only its field is shown.

API key OAuth token

Anthropic API key in use

A key issued from the Anthropic console (starts sk-ant-).

Configured — ends x7q2 Test Clear

A key is stored. Leave this blank to keep it.

Model

Used for the context compiler and the debrief pipeline.

claude-opus-5

Where the data is kept On this machine

Engagements, their meetings, the documents you attach and the words you add. A single file on this machine unless you point it somewhere else.

In use now

Read from the service, with any password removed.

sqlite:///home/you/.elicta/state.db

Save

Credentials configured, with the one in use marked

Then press **Test**. It really tests — it checks the credential against the service rather than reporting "configured" as though that meant "working".

Four behaviours here will look odd until you know why:

What you see	Why
The key field is always empty	Elicita never sends a stored key back to the screen. It shows the last four characters instead, which is enough to tell one key from another.
Leaving it blank keeps the old one	So saving an unrelated setting cannot wipe your key by accident.
Clear is a separate button	Removing a credential is its own deliberate action, because it cannot be undone.

What you see	Why
Key or token, never both boxes	You say which kind you have and only that one is asked for.

Transcription services can wait. They are set up separately, and in this build nothing is connected to them yet — see *What to expect* below. Skip them on your first pass.

Step 2 — Add your client

Engagements. Two minutes.

Elicita opens on your clients. Each one is an **engagement**, and adding one asks three things: who they are, the sector, and the commercial shape of the work.

The screenshot shows the 'Your clients' interface in Elicita. At the top, there's a header with the Elicita logo and the word 'ENGAGEMENTS'. Below this is the title 'Your clients'. Underneath, there's a section titled 'ENGAGEMENTS' which contains a list of two existing engagements. Each engagement card shows the client name, a brief description, and two buttons: 'Current' (green) and 'Open' (blue). The first engagement is 'Northwind Logistics' with the description 'Freight and logistics · Fixed-price discovery, three meetings'. The second is 'Calder & Rowe' with 'Professional services · Matter-management replacement'. Below the list, there's a paragraph explaining that opening an engagement makes it the client for other screens, and removing it takes it off the list. Then, there's a section titled 'NEW ENGAGEMENT' which contains a form with three input fields: 'Client organisation' (with 'Northwind Logistics' entered), 'Sector' (with 'Freight and logistics' entered), and 'Commercial context' (with 'Fixed-price discovery, three meetings' entered). Below the form, there's a paragraph explaining that the sector and commercial shape are not filing. At the bottom, there's a button 'Create engagement' and a note 'Ready when all three are filled in'.

Your clients, and the form for adding one

That is not filing. It is what lets Elicita work out which languages to expect in the room, so nobody has to be asked to choose one before a meeting starts.

Opening a client makes it the one every other screen is about.

The single most common confusion. A screen that looks empty is far more often pointed at a different client than genuinely empty. The switcher at the top of the window, beside the screen's name, follows you everywhere — that is the first place to check. Your choice is remembered between sessions.

Step 3 — Add its first meeting

One minute.

An engagement is a client. A **meeting** is one conversation with them — and everything after this point (recording, the live panel, the write-up) is about a meeting, so an engagement needs at least one before any of it applies.

Adding one asks a single question: how the audio will reach Elicita. A line-in from the meeting machine, a silent join that takes the call audio, or a microphone. You can change it later.

Step 4 — Give it what you already have

Preparation screen. Ten to twenty minutes, and the highest-value time you will spend.

Documents. Scoping decks, throughput studies, the last proposal. Drop the files straight onto the screen, or pick them with the button beside the drop area. Elicita reads what is *inside* them — Word, PowerPoint, Excel and PDF alike, not just the filename.

Tag each one, because the tag changes how Elicita treats it:

Tag	What it means
Ground truth	Established fact. If a client contradicts it, that is worth interrupting a meeting for.
Hypothesis	Our assumption, not theirs. Produces questions to verify, not contradictions to flag.
Superseded	Kept for background, never used to challenge anyone.

You can also attach a document by its SharePoint, OneDrive or Teams link — but that is the one thing here that must be set up first, and until it is, pasting a link is refused with a message saying so. That refusal is deliberate: a link recorded but never read would sit in the list looking like preparation that had happened.

The client's own words. Product names, internal systems, their jargon — the words a transcription service has no way of knowing.

This is the most effective single thing you can do for accuracy, and it is worth more than any other preparation on this screen. A misheard product name does not just look sloppy: it reads to Elicita as something brand new, and it will interrupt you to ask about a system that does not exist. A typo in this list is worth correcting the moment you notice it — a wrong word handed to the transcription service is worse than no word at all, because it makes the transcript confidently wrong rather than merely uncertain.

Nothing you remove here is erased. A document's **Remove**, a word's small ✕, and removing the whole engagement all just stop it appearing; the record is kept. So tidy freely — but know that removing a client is *not* how you would honour a request to erase their data. Elicita does not do that yet.

Step 5 — Draft the questions, then read them

Press Compile, then go and make coffee.

Elicita reads everything you gave it and drafts the questions worth asking, grouped by the section of your requirements template each one serves.

The screenshot shows the Elicita preparation interface for a project titled "Northwind Logistics". The interface is divided into several sections:

- REFERENCE DOCUMENTS:** A list of documents with their roles and actions.

Document	Role	Action
Current-state scoping deck	ground truth	Remove
Warehouse throughput study 2025	ground truth	Remove
Proposed integration approach	hypothesis	Remove
Original RFP response	superseded	Remove

 Below this is a field for "SharePoint, OneDrive or Teams link" with a URL and an "Attach" button.
- Drop documents here:** A box for uploading files, tagged as "ground truth".
- ENGAGEMENT VOCABULARY:** A section for defining terms. It shows a list of terms: Northwind, Zephyr WMS, Consignment, Cross-dock, SLA-4. Below is a form to add a new term: "A word the client uses" (Zephyr WMS) and "Product name" (dropdown) with an "Add term" button.
- QUESTION BANK:** A list of questions grouped by section.
 - Performance (2 questions):**
 - When you say the dashboard has to be fast, what does that mean in seconds? (Priority 1) [Move up] [Prune]
 - Is that response time at median load, or at your Monday morning peak? (Priority 2) [Move up] [Prune]
 - Integrations (2 questions):**
 - Which systems does Zephyr WMS have to talk to on day one? (Priority 1) [Move up] [Prune]
 - Are those integrations real-time, or is a nightly batch acceptable? (Priority 2) [Move up] [Prune]
 - Volumes (1 question):**
 - How many consignments a day at peak, and how far above average is that? (Priority 1) [Move up] [Prune]
- MEETINGS:** A section for scheduling meetings. It shows a meeting titled "Discovery 3 — integrations and volumes" with a line-in from the meeting machine. Below is a form to add a meeting: "How the audio is captured" (Line-in from the meeting machine) and an "Add meeting" button.

The preparation screen: documents, vocabulary, and the question bank grouped by section

Drafting is slow work, so it is handed off as a job that finishes some minutes later; Elicita goes back for the result on its own and fills the bank when it arrives. **Compile before you make coffee, not while the client is waiting.** While it is working the screen says so, and will not let you start a second one on top of it.

Then do the part that matters: **read the questions, move the ones that matter up, and prune the ones that miss.** Pruning is not deletion — a pruned question is kept as a record of your judgement and stays pruned in every later meeting, so redrafting the bank never brings it back for you to reject twice.

This review is worth doing even if you never open Elicita during the meeting. A good question list makes you better prepared on its own, which is why it comes first and why you are meant to edit it rather than trust it.

If the bank comes back empty

The screen tells you which of these it was — it names the step that stopped and what to do about it. The four causes have four different fixes, and only one of them is waiting:

1. **Nothing set up** — drafting needs the AI provider from step 1.
2. **Nothing was read** — if every document you added was a *link* and your Microsoft 365 tenant is not registered, none of them were read. You would have seen each link refused at the time. Drop the files in instead.
3. **It is still working** — normal. Give it minutes, not seconds.
4. **A credential problem** — a key not permitted to use the model you chose, a provider throttling you, or a network it could not cross.

One kind of document contributes nothing either way: a **scanned PDF**, where the page is really a photograph of a page. Elicita will not guess at words in a picture, so it adds nothing rather than nonsense. If a scan is the only copy you have, put that document's important words in the vocabulary list instead.

Step 6 — Run the meeting

Consent first, and in this build it is yours to handle. As it ships today, Elicita does not stop to ask for consent before a meeting, and writes no consent record. The screen says so in as many words, and is careful to report that nothing has been recorded here rather than showing you a reassuring tick.


BEFORE RECORDING

Discovery 3 — integrations and volumes

CONSENT

Consent model
standing for the engagement

Not required for this meeting
This engagement does not ask for consent at each meeting, so nothing is recorded here.

Not asked

WHAT HAPPENS TO THE AUDIO

Never written to disk
Audio stays in memory for the duration of transcription.

Destroyed after transcription
The moment the recording has been transcribed and diarized, the audio is deleted and the deletion is recorded.

Vendors told not to retain
Sent as a parameter on every request, not only in the contract.

On

CAPTURE

Line-in from the meeting machine
Platform voice processing is off — it is tuned for a listener, and removes detail the transcriber uses.

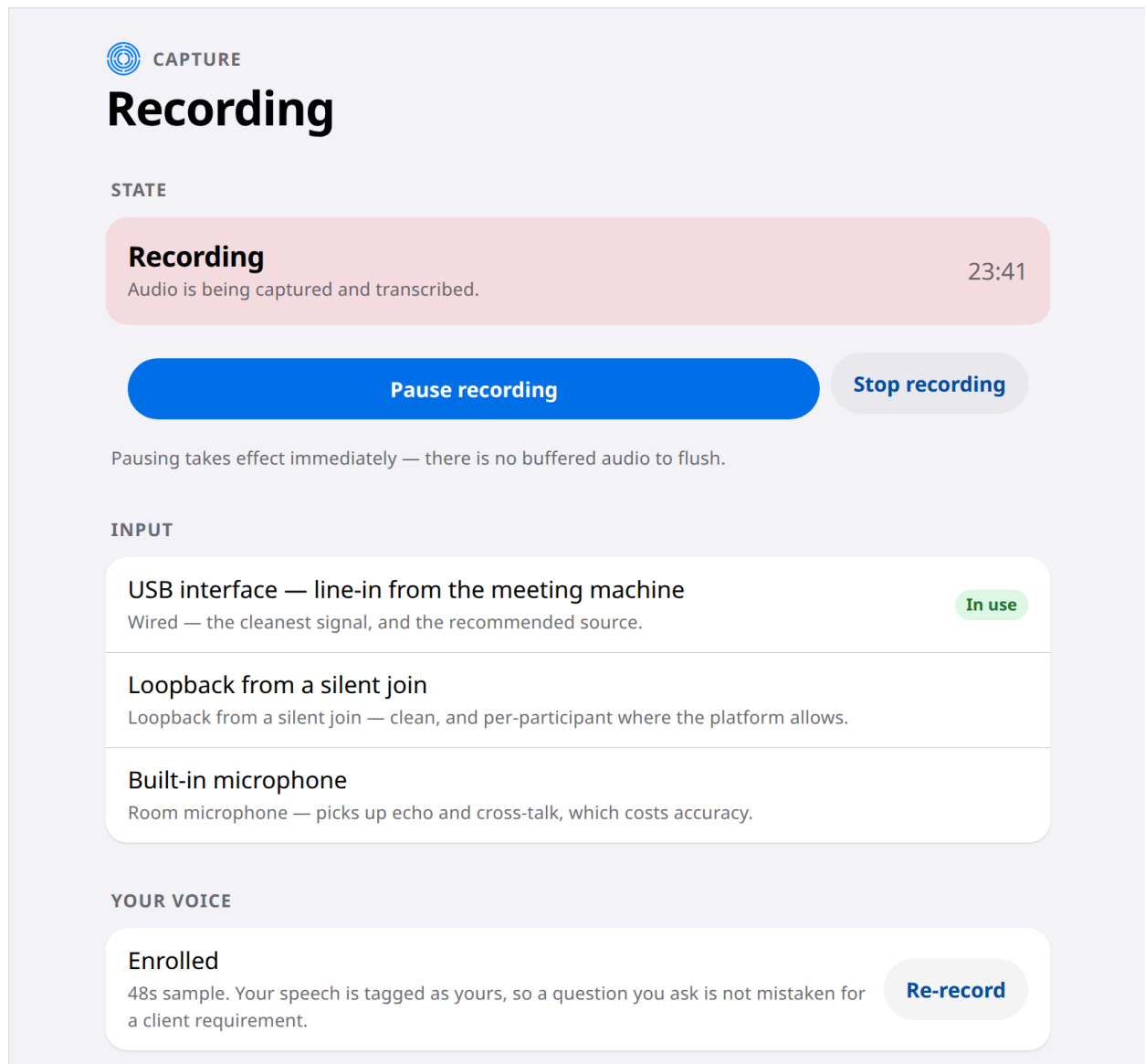
Start

Consent is not being asked for, and nothing is on record

So having the consent conversation — and being able to show later that you had it — rests with you, not with the software. The gate that would hold recording shut is built and works, but nothing can switch an engagement over to it yet.

What you can tell the client about the audio, truthfully, before a second of it exists: it is never written to disk, it lives in memory only while it is being turned into text, it is destroyed the moment that finishes — and the deletion is itself recorded — and the transcription service is told with every request not to keep it.

Starting. Pick the input before you start, rather than discovering afterwards that it took the wrong one. Elicita will argue for a better microphone: a wired input or a silent join is markedly more accurate than a mic in the middle of the table, because people talking over each other causes more transcription errors than the choice of service does. A room mic earns a warning that stays on screen.



Recording, with pause one tap away

Pause is the control to know. You reach for it when a client says *"can we take this bit off the record."* It is the largest thing on the screen, never moves, takes effect immediately, and does not ask whether you are sure. Stopping sits beside it, deliberately smaller — it ends the recording and hands the microphone back, and is not what you want under your thumb when you meant to pause. Audio captured while paused is discarded, and resuming is instant.

CAPTURE

Paused

STATE

Paused 23:41
No audio is reaching the transcriber. Nothing said now is captured.

Resume recording **Stop recording**

Pausing takes effect immediately — there is no buffered audio to flush.

INPUT

USB interface — line-in from the meeting machine **In use**
Wired — the cleanest signal, and the recommended source.

Loopback from a silent join
Loopback from a silent join — clean, and per-participant where the platform allows.

Built-in microphone
Room microphone — picks up echo and cross-talk, which costs accuracy.

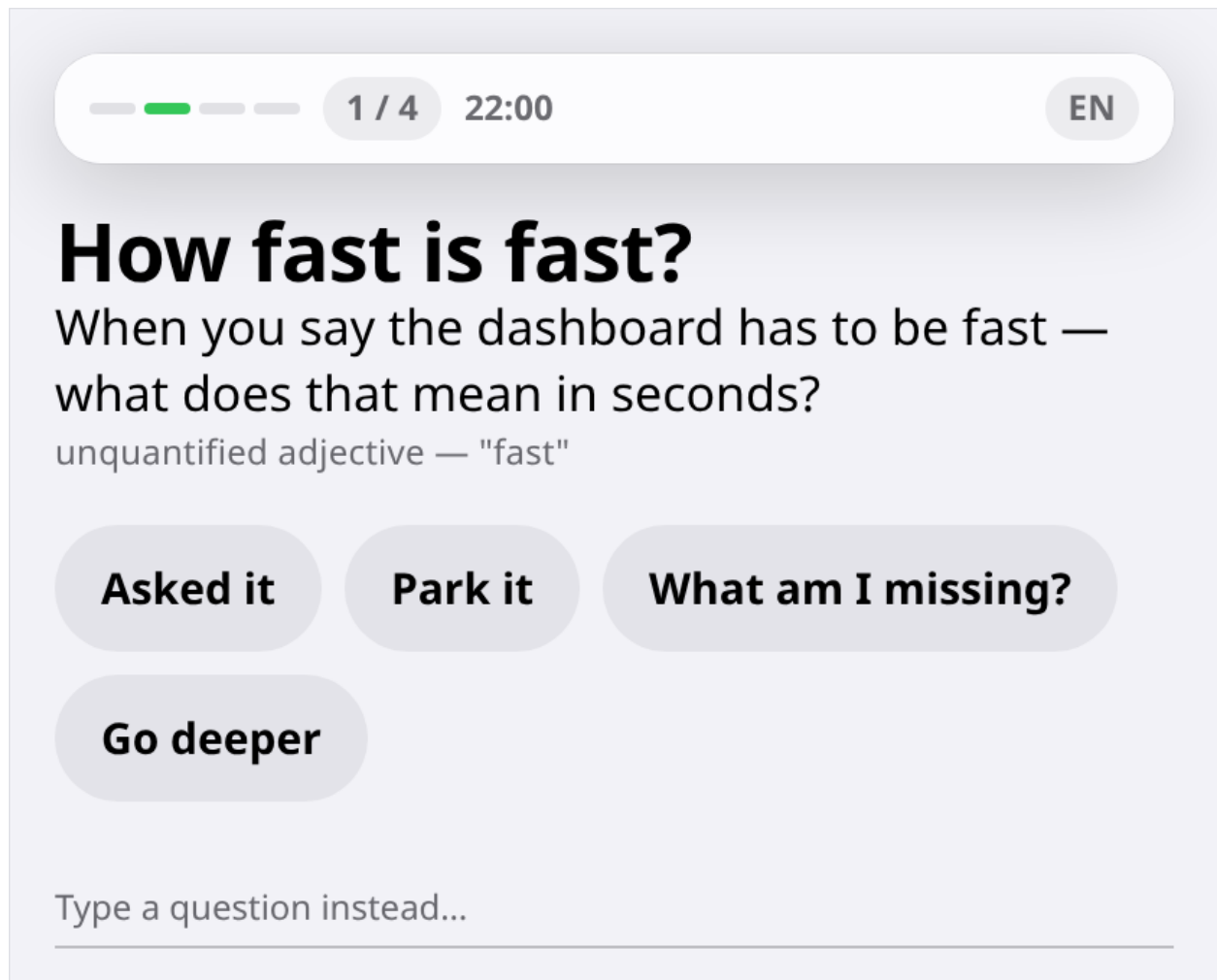
YOUR VOICE

Enrolled **Re-record**
48s sample. Your speech is tagged as yours, so a question you ask is not mistaken for a client requirement.

Paused, and saying so unmistakably

The state is said three ways at once — the word, the sentence under it, and the colour — and never by colour alone, because believing you are paused while still recording is the worst thing this product could do to you.

The panel, when a suggestion arrives, gives you three things in the order you need them: the short version readable without breaking eye contact, the full wording if you want to ask it verbatim, and quietly underneath, *why it fired* — which is how you tell in half a second whether Elicita understood the room.



A suggested question, and why it fired

Every response is one tap: **Asked it** (the section fills in immediately), **Park it** (kept for the write-up), **Go deeper** (follow the thread), or **What am I missing?** (it names the biggest uncovered topic).

Step 7 — Afterwards

Open the debrief screen and **ask about the meeting in your own words** — *what did they actually say about the March deadline, draft me the paragraph about integrations*. Answers quote and attribute rather than summarise, and say plainly when something was worked out rather than said.



Ask about this meeting

Northwind Logistics — Discovery 2

CONVERSATION

YOU

What did they actually say about the March deadline?

ELICTA

Priya Raman (Ops, 08:15) said “the pilot has to be live before the March peak — after that nobody has time to look at it.” She did not give a date, so March 31 is inferred from “before the March peak”, not stated. It is still an open question.

YOU

Draft the follow-up paragraph about integrations.

ELICTA

Suggested: “As discussed, the pilot covers the dispatch and telematics feeds only. The warehouse management system is out of scope for this phase — we agreed to revisit it once the dispatch integration is stable.” This rests on Dan Okoro (IT, 22:40) and the scope note in your engagement brief.

YOUR QUESTION

Ask anything about what was said

What did they say about the March deadline?

Ask

Asking a question about the meeting in your own words

The intended output is four documents: the open questions ranked by how much they matter, a log of decisions, a draft project brief, and a follow-up email for you to read and send — never sent for you. Every claim carries its source, and is labelled **Stated** (the client said it; check the wording) or **Inferred** (Elicita concluded it; judge whether you agree). A claim without a source cannot be saved at all.

If a step of the write-up fails, the sequence stops there and says which step and why, rather than passing invented material to the next one. A partial result with an explanation is recoverable; a complete-looking document with a fabricated section is not.

Into the next meeting, the open questions lead the screen, ahead of completed work — what you settled is behind you, and what you did not is what you are walking back in to deal with. A question that has come through three meetings unanswered is flagged, because there are only two explanations and both matter: it is genuinely hard, or it is being deflected.

What to expect on your first run — honestly

This build is not finished, and it is better to know where before your first client meeting than during it.

What is finished changes with every build, so this chapter deliberately does not list it. The last chapter of this book does, and it is rewritten from the product's own notes each time the book is built — which is why it is the one to read before you promise anything to anyone. A list copied into this chapter would be out of date within a fortnight and would look just as confident.

The honest shape of your first real meeting, in a sentence: **Elicita is a very good prepared-question list, a recorder, and an after-the-fact way to interrogate what was said.** The in-the-room suggestion — the thing it is ultimately for — is built, tested, and waiting on one missing service. Which of the two halves you are in is what that last chapter tells you.

If something looks wrong

Symptom	First thing to check
A screen is empty	The client switcher at the top of the window. It is far more often pointed elsewhere than genuinely empty.
The question bank is empty	The screen names which of the four causes it was. Note that a failed compile's explanation does not survive restarting the service — press Compile again to get the current answer.
Pasting a document link is refused	Microsoft 365 registration is not set up. Drop the file in instead; that path needs nothing.
Start recording is greyed out	The screen says which: the page is not secure, the browser offers no microphone access, or the machine has no microphone attached.
No microphone in a browser	Browsers only hand it over on a secure page — on a plain address the capability is <i>absent</i> , not blocked, so there is no prompt to accept. That one is yours to fix and takes a moment.
A permission prompt during a client meeting	It should have been pushed out through device management, which grants microphone and screen-recording access centrally. Agree the endpoint-security exception <i>before</i> the pilot, not during it — it is the single most common cause of a bad first impression.

What Elicita deliberately will not do

Worth knowing on day one, because each is a choice rather than a gap:

- **It never speaks to the client.** No voice, no messages, nothing on your behalf. Ignore it for ninety minutes and nothing happens — that is a supported way to use it.
- **You cannot talk to it during a meeting.** Anything inviting you to type has taken your attention off the client, which is the exact problem it exists to relieve. Asking it things in your own words is an afterwards activity.
- **It stays quiet when unsure.** One suggestion that embarrasses you in front of a client does more damage than ten good ones repair, so it will sometimes miss what a sharp analyst would have caught. That trade was made knowingly.
- **It does not replace judgement.** It notices, suggests, and writes down what it heard. What matters, what to push on, and when the room has had enough stays with you.

The five-minute version

1. Settings -> fill in the AI provider -> **Test**.
 2. Add the client. Add a meeting to it.
 3. Drop your documents on the Preparation screen. Tag them.
 4. Type the client's product names and jargon into the vocabulary list.
 5. **Compile**. Go and make coffee.
 6. Read the drafted questions. Reorder. Prune.
 7. Walk into the meeting better prepared than you were — which is most of the value, and available today.
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Where to read more

Everything here is covered again slowly in the chapters that follow, with every screen shown. The one to read next is the chapter on preparing for an engagement, because that is where the hour you spend pays for itself. The one to read before you promise anything to anyone is the last chapter, on what works today.